The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Chris Wright, America's energy secretary, said the war against **Iran** is "likely" to end within a few weeks. But, he warned, there is "no guarantee" that energy prices will fall soon. Meanwhile Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, said that Iran was open to talks with other countries about allowing safe passage for their vessels through the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran fired missiles at **Israel** on Sunday, according to the Israel Defence Forces. Among the targets was Tel Aviv. Israeli media reported that at least eight people were injured in separate attacks. Meanwhile Israeli officials told Reuters, a news agency, that Israel and Lebanon could soon enter negotiations aimed at securing a ceasefire and disarming Hizbullah, an Iran-backed Shia militia.

Senior officials from **America** and **China** met in Paris to prepare for a summit between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping this month. The talks are thought to have focused on tariffs and on export controls imposed by both countries: China has in the past restricted rare-earth exports and America has curtailed sales of technology. Analysts say a breakthrough is unlikely because America is preoccupied with the war with Iran.

Israeli attacks killed at least 16 Palestinians in **Gaza** and the West Bank, according to Palestinian health officials, one of the highest daily tolls in weeks. An air strike in Gaza killed several police officers travelling in a vehicle. In the West Bank Israeli troops fired on a car, killing four members of a family. Israel's government said it was investigating the incident.

Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, said Ukraine is willing to share its expertise in shooting down Iranian-made drones with Middle Eastern countries, but wants payment or technological support in return. Ukraine has sent teams to several countries to advise on air defences. Ukrainian forces have been intercepting such drones since Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022.

Japan said it will release oil from its strategic reserves to hold down fuel prices, which are rising because the Iran war is disrupting shipments from the Middle East. The government plans to release 80m barrels—roughly 45 days of consumption. Japan imports 90% of its oil from the Middle East.

Five people were arrested in **Cuba** after a Communist Party building was vandalised following a rally. Rare displays of public anger have broken out across the country, provoked by spiralling food prices and power cuts, which are becoming longer and more unpredictable. America's oil embargo, imposed in January, is widening divisions between poor and prosperous Cubans.

Word of the week: Tilly tax, guild royalties paid by film studios for using AI-generated actors. Ahead of the Oscars, read what nobody at the Hollywood bash wants you to know.

Photograph: Getty Images

France heads to the polls

France votes in the first round of mayoral elections on Sunday. For some cities, including Paris, the race looks tight. The capital has been held by socialists for 25 years. Polls suggest a close contest between two front-runners: Emmanuel Grégoire, a socialist, and Rachida Dati, on the centre-right. The outcome will largely depend on whether candidates who qualify for the second-round vote on March 22nd withdraw in favour of a tactical alliance with a better-placed contender.

Marine Le Pen's populist-right National Rally and its friends have their eyes on the town hall in Nice. Their candidate there, Eric Ciotti, who defected from the centre-right, is trying to dethrone Christian Estrosi, an ally of Emmanuel Macron's centrists. The president's party, which has never put down strong local roots, looks set to struggle. Edouard Philippe, a former prime minister and mayor of Le Havre, could also face difficulties. If he is not re-elected, he has suggested he will not stand for the presidency in 2027.

Photograph: Getty Images

A new Kazakhstan?

On Sunday Kazakhstan will vote in a referendum on sweeping changes to its constitution, which include shrinking the parliament. Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, the president, says they will improve checks and balances in the authoritarian country. Critics warn that it may have the opposite effect. They fear Mr Tokayev may argue that resetting the constitution should also reset the term limits of serving presidents—a loophole favoured by several Central Asian autocrats and Russia's Vladimir Putin.

Mr Tokayev has promised to leave office in 2029, in accordance with the single-term limit he introduced in 2022 to prevent political power grabs. His predecessor, Nursultan Nazarbayev, ruled for three decades, before handing over to Mr Tokayev in a choreographed succession in 2019. Mr Tokayev later promised to do away with such "super-presidential" powers, and cracked down on some of Mr Nazarbayev's cronies for their extraordinary wealth. That will be seen as gross hypocrisy if he uses the new constitution to cling to power instead.

Photograph: Getty Images

Is a nuclear-energy renaissance under way?

The energy crisis in the Gulf is reviving interest in nuclear power. Since the Iran war began Brazil, Belgium, Britain, China, Italy and South Korea have all made new commitments to increase nuclear capacity. Existing plans in France and Japan have gained momentum. India agreed to buy 11,000 tons of uranium from Canada for $1.9bn, the largest such deal ever. America approved its first advanced nuclear reactor.

It is not the first time volatile energy markets have given nuclear a boost. Worldwide fuel shortages, caused by Arab states' oil embargo in 1973 and the Iranian revolution in 1979, also drove investment into nuclear energy. By 1996 nuclear power was generating 17.5% of all electricity. But that share has been decreasing steadily since, mostly because of high-profile disasters and high capital costs. The need to limit global warming by slashing greenhouse-gas emissions has never been powerful enough to reverse that trend. An energy panic may have changed the calculus.

Photograph: Getty Images

The Winter Paralympics has a climate problem

For the organisers of the Winter Paralympics, which concludes in Cortina, Italy, on Sunday, the past fortnight has been anything but smooth. For the first time since it invaded Ukraine in 2022, Russia was permitted to send a team and fly its flag at a major global sporting event. The silence that greeted its athletes at the opening ceremony showed the decision was far from popular. Ukraine and 15 other countries boycotted the event. Meanwhile, Iran's sole winter Paralympian, Aboulfazl Khatibi, was unable to travel.

The difficulties did not end there. Unseasonably warm weather left snowboarders and skiers navigating slushy courses, elevating the risk of injury and impairing performance. "I don't believe that the Paralympics should be happening right now," concluded Amy Purdy, an American snowboarder. As winters become milder, pressure to bring the Winter Paralympics forward to January or February, or merge it with the Olympics, will only intensify.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of the week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Carlos Flexa Ribeiro, Rio de Janeiro, Brazil

Jan Redeby, Maseru, Lesotho

Enzo Orsini, Naples, Florida

They all gave the correct answers of: Licence to Kill, The Painted Veil, Cake by the Ocean, groom and ring. The theme is a wedding, where the couple needs a licence, the bride sometimes wears a veil, everyone eats cake and the groom and bride exchange rings.

The questions were:

Monday: Which was the second and last Bond film to feature Timothy Dalton?

Tuesday: Which William Somerset Maugham novel features a cholera epidemic in China?

Wednesday: What was the biggest hit by DNCE, a rock band whose lead singer was Joe Jonas?

Thursday: What is another term for someone who works as a stable hand?

Friday: Which word links the venues for a circus performance and a boxing match?

We know not through our intellect, but through our experience.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty